

Study Questions: Agents

1. What distinguishes an agent from a non-agentive bounded system in the Active Inference framework?
2. How does the asymmetry between sensory and active states in a Markov Blanket give rise to agency?
3. Explain Spinoza's concept of *conatus* and compare it with the Active Inference account of self-maintenance.
4. What is a "self-model" in Metzinger's sense, and how does it relate to the generative model in Active Inference?
5. Can a bacterium have a self? Defend your answer using concepts from this module.
6. How does Heidegger's concept of *Sorge* (care) relate to the Active Inference understanding of agency?
7. State the "problem of other minds." How does Active Inference reframe it as a problem of inference?
8. Compare the simulation theory and theory-theory of mind reading. How does Active Inference relate to each?
9. Is agency an intrinsic property of certain systems or a description imposed by external observers? Present arguments for both views.
10. What role does intentionality play in philosophical accounts of agency, and how does Active Inference handle it?
11. Husserl described intentionality as "aboutness" — consciousness is always consciousness *of* something. How does this map onto the generative model's relationship to external states?
12. Can a thermostat be an agent under the Active Inference definition? What philosophical consequences follow from your answer?
13. If agency exists on a continuum from bacteria to humans, where (if anywhere) does moral responsibility begin?
14. How does Dewey's concept of the "organism-environment transaction" anticipate the Active Inference framework?
15. What is the relationship between agency and autonomy? Can an agent lack autonomy?

16. How does the concept of active states in a Markov Blanket relate to Gibson's concept of affordances?
17. Evaluate the claim: "Free will is the experience of being a system that minimizes its own free energy."
18. What does Varela mean by "sense-making"? How does it compare with the Active Inference account of agency?
19. How might the concept of agency in Active Inference apply to collective systems — swarms, organizations, or societies?
20. Construct a philosophical argument that distinguishes genuine agency from mere reactivity. Where does Active Inference draw this line, if at all?